

Leadership isn't about runs and rants, it's about trust. And Shubman Gill earned it in spades. With a mammoth tally of 754 runs, Gill surpassed Sunil Gavaskar's milestone of most runs by an Indian captain (732 vs West Indies in 1978) in a series

SHUBMAN GILL 25

Captain; Right-handed batsman

Test Matches: 37
Runs: 2,647
Avg: 41.35
Highest score 269

What the world saw as a young, inexperienced side was deemed by coach Gautam Gambhir as a "gun team". And in that squad, only Shubman Gill could have taken on the role of the tank gunner. In his first stint as captain and No.4 bat, Gill scored a century and followed it up with two stellar knocks of 269 and 161 in Edgbaston, setting India up for a comprehensive win. When he faltered at Lord's, so did India. But it was the series-saving century in Old Trafford that demonstrated he could handle pressure and step up when it mattered most. With each passing match, Gill settled in, showing his ease at taking on dual responsibilities. "I have more clarity on the areas that we need to work on as a team and as a captain," he said at the conclusion of the series. "I was thinking more for the team, which helped me to take the pressure off myself." This consummate self-awareness offers proof that the future of Indian cricket is in safe, reliable hands. It helps that they also unleash strokes that run bowlers ragged.

—Suhani Singh

Watching from afar, India's former offie mainstay Ravichandran Ashwin articulated it best on his YouTube channel: "Somebody will rise up. When we're pushed to the wall, this Indian team becomes a different beast." And that beast roared at The Oval. From a dominant 301/3, while chasing only 374, England capitulated, losing seven wickets for 66 runs. Pressure changes sides. India smelled blood, and Siraj delivered the final blow. After the last rites were performed, a question was asked: what have you learned about yourself and the team in the past six weeks? "Never give up," captain Shubman Gill said, almost instinctively. Those three words captured the ethos of this young side that had stared down adversity, injury and the weight of expectation—and never blinked.

Nothing summed up the spirit of Gill and Co. better than Siraj, bowling his fourth fastest ball of the series, at 146 kmph, at the fag end of a two-month-long tour, having already hurled 1,100-plus deliveries during the series. And